Intelligence Committee (2005–11), tactical links with the likes of Rocketi 'impacted our [India's] understanding of the situation on the ground, and we started exploring ways to engage more with these figures'.[26] Most such on-the-ground links were established by the military intelligence (and some MEA officers), according to Khare, but not the R&AW. Shivshankar Menon categorically says that though the conciliatory thread of understanding and accommodating the Afghan Taliban ran through India's policy circles even before 2001, 'it [engagement with the Afghan Taliban] became much more necessary after 2003–04 ... because it was clear by then that the Taliban had not really been wiped out ... so it was worth finding out what explains their longevity, their survival, and what kind of prospects they had'.[27]

For Sahgal, a retired senior Indian army officer, India's Afghanistan policy did not witness any abrupt, radical, shifts, but New Delhi was determined about testing waters and building relations with all Afghan factions. As early as 2002, he says, Indian diplomats including Katju were 'going around [Afghanistan] spending a huge amount of money and talking to these Taliban people for good behavior'.[28] Despite being a partisan against Pakistan-supported Afghan groups, and very close to the former UF leaders, Katju was directed by his bosses to ascertain the extent to which India could engage with the Afghan Taliban without getting tied down to the movement or risk losing legitimacy over its actions. Such engagement often, allegedly, included giving briefcases full of cash to both mainstream and insurgent Afghan leaders.[29] The aim of such covert financial deals could range from ensuring safety of Indians working in Afghanistan and gaining hard intelligence about Pakistan-supported groups, to reducing the Taliban's financial dependence on Rawalpindi by out-financing Pakistan. This aspect of outmatching and out-funding Pakistan in hiring militant 'mercenaries' operating along the Afghanistan-Pakistan border was publicly articulated by India's current national security advisor Ajit Doval in 2014.[30] Whether Indian intelligence agencies cultivated the Afghan Taliban or other freelance armed militants in the region, however, remains unknown (though actively alleged by the Pakistani media).

These kidnap-and-kill incidents highlighted (at a high human cost) that not all Taliban factions were anti-India, not all Taliban were ideologues, and internal